Music Brings Joy to Veterans in Hospital

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-11-11 3 min read

Dante Ciolfi opens his guitar case in a hospital in Washington, D.C. He is going to play songs for patients. Ciolfi is a **volunteer** with Musicians On Call, a group that brings live music to hospital patients all over the country. Ellen Morris is another **volunteer**. She leads the musicians from room to room. At the **hospice** wing, she knocks on a door. 'I have my friend Dante here that would love to play a song for you today,' she says. The first patient is Lawrence Ludden, a 93-year-old Army **veteran**. Ciolfi sings 'Desperado' by the Eagles. Ludden smiles and claps. Next, Ciolfi plays for John Fay, a **Marine veteran** who cannot speak. Fay taps his heart as he listens. Then Sidney Nichols, an **Air Force veteran**, hears 'Crazy Love' and starts to sing along. 'I like it,' he says. Since this story was reported, Sidney Nichols has died. Musicians On Call has played for more than a million patients since 1999. Ciolfi says playing a song is one tiny thing he can do for **veterans**.

Word Treasure

volunteer -- A volunteer is someone who does work for free to help others.
hospice -- A hospice is a place where people who are very ill get care and comfort.
veteran -- A veteran is someone who served in the armed forces.
Marine -- A Marine is a member of the U.S. Marine Corps.
Air Force -- The Air Force is the part of the armed forces that uses planes.

Background you need

Musicians On Call is a group that brings live music to hospital patients all over the country.

Its volunteers play songs for patients, including veterans who are in the hospital.

Music can make a hard day in the hospital feel a little brighter, and a familiar song can make patients smile and sing along.

Break it down

WHO: Dante Ciolfi, a volunteer musician with Musicians On Call, and Ellen Morris, who leads the musicians from room to room.

WHAT: Volunteer musicians play live music for hospital patients, including veterans like Lawrence Ludden, John Fay, and Sidney Nichols.

WHERE: In a hospital in Washington, D.C., including the hospice wing.

WHY: Because live music can bring comfort and joy to people who are sick and far from home.

Why it matters

Music can lift your mood when you feel sick or lonely, and playing a song for someone is a simple way to make their day better.

Test what you remember

1. Who is Dante Ciolfi?

- (A) A patient in the hospice wing
- (B) A doctor at the hospital
- (C) A music teacher at a school
- (D) A volunteer with Musicians On Call

2. What group brings live music to hospital patients?

- (A) The Eagles
- (B) The hospital choir
- (C) Musicians On Call
- (D) The Army band

3. Which song did Ciolfi sing for Lawrence Ludden?

- (A) 'Confessions on a Dance Floor'
- (B) 'Bring Your Love'
- (C) 'Desperado'
- (D) 'Crazy Love'

4. How old is Lawrence Ludden?

- (A) 93 years old
- (B) 63 years old
- (C) 83 years old
- (D) 73 years old

5. What did John Fay do as he listened to the music?

- (A) He asked for another song
- (B) He tapped his heart
- (C) He clapped his hands
- (D) He sang along

6. How many patients has Musicians On Call played for since 1999?

- (A) More than a hundred
- (B) More than ten thousand
- (C) More than a thousand
- (D) More than a million

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Dante Ciolfi: Says playing a song is one tiny thing he can do for veterans.
2. Sidney Nichols: Sang along to 'Crazy Love' and said he liked it.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):